Ilkka Hanski



Widely seen as the father of metapopulation theory, Ilkka Hanski was born in Lempäälä, Finland, in 1953. As a child, he collected butterflies, and after finding a rare species, he devoted his life to ecology, studying at the universities of Helsinki and Oxford.

Ecologists at the time paid little attention to the distribution of local species populations, but Hanski realized this was crucial, and spent much of his career testing his metapopulation theory by mapping out and recording more than 4,000 habitat patches for the Glanville fritillary butterfly on the Åland Islands. This work earned Hanski global fame, and enabled him to establish the Metapopulation Research Centre in Helsinki, which became one the world's leading focuses of ecological research. Hanski died of cancer in May 2016.

Key works

1991 *Metapopulation Dynamics*

1999 *Metapopulation Ecology*

2016 *Messages from Islands*

See also: Animal ecology • Clutch control • Island biogeography • Metacommunities